NSA collected bulk data on Americans. But no so-called mainstream publication at all covered a rare public appearance by Ira "Gus" Hunt, the chief technology officer of the CIA.

I'd known Gus slightly from my Dell stint with the CIA. He was one of our top customers, and every vendor loved his apparent inability to be discreet: he'd always tell you more than he was supposed to. For sales guys, he was like a bag of money with a mouth. Now he was appearing as a special guest speaker at a civilian tech event in New York called the GigaOM Structure: Data conference. Anyone with $40 could go to it. The major talks, such as Gus's, were streamed for free live online.

The reason I'd made sure to catch his talk was that I'd just read, through internal NSA channels, that the CIA had finally decided on the disposition of its cloud contract. It had refused my old team at Dell, and turned down HP, too, instead signing a ten-year, $600 million cloud development and management deal with Amazon. I had no negative feelings about this—actually, at this juncture, I was pleased that my work wasn't going to be used by the agency. I was just curious, from a professional standpoint, whether Gus might obliquely address this announcement and offer any insight into why Amazon had been chosen, since rumors were going around that the proposal process had been rigged in Amazon's favor.

I got insight, certainly, but of an unexpected kind. I had the opportunity of witnessing the highest-ranking technical officer at the CIA stand onstage in a rumpled suit and brief a crowd of uncleared normies—and, via the Internet, the uncleared world—about the agency's ambitions and capacities. As his presentation unfolded, and he alternated bad jokes with an even worse command of PowerPoint, I grew more and more incredulous.

"At the CIA," he said, "we fundamentally try to collect everything and hang on to it forever." As if that wasn't clear enough, he went on: "It is nearly within our grasp to compute on <u>all</u> human generated information." The underline was Gus's own. He was reading from his slide deck, ugly words in an ugly font illustrated with the government's signature four-color clip art.

There were a few journalists in the crowd, apparently, though it seemed as if almost all of them were from specialty tech-government publications like *Federal Computer Week*. It was telling that Gus stuck around for a Q & A toward the conclusion of his presentation. Rather, it wasn't quite a Q & A, but more like an auxiliary presentation, offered directly to the journalists. He must have been trying to get something off his chest, and it wasn't just his clown tie.